and a civil war potentially looming, it was likely to be some time before British diplomacy could be brought to bear on whoever finally succeeded the dead Maharajah.

More serious still were the implications for feeding and supplying the Army of the Indus: what chance would there be of sending food, arms, money and reinforcements into Afghanistan when disorders looked almost certain to engulf the Punjab plains separating the invading army from its supply base in British India? Already isolated, the Army of the Indus was now looking increasingly cut off, with the Punjab closing up behind it. Meanwhile, the army was marching ever deeper into the mountains of Central Asia, with ever longer and more vulnerable supply routes, and beyond any easy assistance should anything go wrong.

A difficult expedition, whose success was far from assured, had just become much more difficult.

The same day that Ranjit Singh was dying in Lahore – 27 June 1839 – the Army of the Indus resumed its march from Kandahar towards Kabul.

The force was now split into three units and moved steadily forward at around ten miles a day. This was a little faster than before due to Keane's decision to leave the vast siege guns that had caused such trouble in the passes. He took this decision having been advised that the fortifications of Ghazni and Kabul were not especially formidable and having been assured by Shuja that his Popalzai clansmen would seize control and open the gates of Ghazni when the army arrived there. In Kandahar a garrison of 3,000 men was left behind under the nominal sovereignty of one of Shuja's younger sons, Prince Fatteh Jang, and under the actual military control of Major-General Nott. Most of the Durrani nobles who had just sworn their allegiance to Shuja also chose to stay; only Haji Khan, ambitious for promotion, chose to accompany the army.

The two-month break in Kandahar had been brought to a close after worrying intelligence had arrived from both Herat in the west and Ghazni to the east. In Herat, the Wazir Yar Mohammad Alikozai was not showing the gratitude that the British had expected him to demonstrate for their part in ending the terrible Persian assault on his city. Instead, within weeks of the Persian retreat, he had quarrelled with the British envoy, Eldred Pottinger, who had just spent £30,000 in charitable disbursements in the city, cut the